amount of water under the surface of the earth. The atmosphere has water in all the three forms. (Solid, liquid, and gas). The total amount of water on the earth does not change over time. Water is constantly in motion within the spheres of the earth which is being transformed and reused all over the earth. The earth's hydrosphere, thus, acts as a closed system.

5.2 Distribution of Land and Water in the Earth

Earth is covered by land and water. About 70.8% of its area (361million sq km) is covered by water and 29.2% (148 million sq km) of its area by land. About 96.5% of water is salty found in seas and oceans. Fresh water occupies only 2.5%. Saline ground water and saline lakes together form 1%.

5.3 Fresh water

Fresh water is defined as water with a salinity of less than 1‰ compared to that of the oceans (i.e. below 0.35‰). Water with salinity between 0.35‰ and 1‰ is typically referred to as marginal water because it is marginal for many uses by humans and animals.

Considering the distribution of fresh water 68.6% of it is locked in Glaciers and icecaps. About 30.1% is stored as ground water and the remaining 1.5% is available as surface water.

Surface water includes ice and snow on the land and sea, water in the lakes, rivers, swamps and marshes, moisture in soil, atmosphere and biosphere. Rivers and lakes are the major sources of fresh water around the world, and are vital to the communities they serve.

Rivers: Rivers generally have a source on a mountain either from a glacier, a spring or a lake. River Ganga has its source from Gangotri glacier in the Himalayas. River Cauvery has its source from a spring in Talacauvery located in Kodagu district of Karnataka. River Nile has its source near Lake Victoria in Uganda. The river flows through confined channel between two banks and ends up at the mouth which is either on a sea or lake. When rivers drain their water into a lake or an inland sea, it is said to be an inland drainage.

The Nile River in Africa is the longest river in the world. The Nile River flows through Egypt, Uganda, Ethiopia, Kenya, Tanzania, Democratic Republic of the Congo, Rwanda, Burundi, Sudan and Eritrea drains and into the Mediterranean Sea forming a delta to the north of Cairo city.

The river Amazon in South America, is the second longest river, and has the largest drainage basin of any river. The Amazon River flows through Peru, Colombia, and Brazil and drains into the Atlantic Ocean forming an estuarine delta.

The Yangtze River, which flows in China, is the longest river in Asia, and the third longest river in the world. The longest river system in the United States, the Mississippi-Missouri system is considered the fourth longest river in the world.



263 rivers either cross or demarcate **international political boundaries.**

The total volume of water in rivers in the world is estimated at 2,120 km^3. Asia

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